

JUSTICES CLEAR WAY FOR TRUMP’S BALLROOM

Court declines to stop construction, though Roberts says the project is likely illegal.

By David G. Savage
and Michael Wilner

WASHINGTON — A divided Supreme Court has cleared the way for President Trump to finish building his new White House ballroom with mostly private money and without approval from Congress.

By a 5-4 vote, the justices granted an emergency appeal from Trump and his lawyers on Monday, setting aside a judge’s order that would stop the construction.

But Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. dissented, along with the court’s three liberals.

Roberts said the construction project was “likely unlawful” and should not be allowed to continue.

“The White House is not just any building ... when it comes to historic preservation,” Roberts wrote. “Winston Churchill once remarked that ‘[w]e shape our buildings, and afterwards our buildings shape us.’ All the more reason to ensure that those responsible follow the rules in deciding what to tear down and what to build up at the People’s House.”

The outcome turned on the standing of the plaintiffs, the National Trust for Historic Preservation and its members.

The conservative majority pointed to Alison Hoagland, one of its members, who said she lives in Washington, walks by the White House about once a month and said she found the “scale,” “height” and “massing” of the huge ballroom to be distasteful.

“This court has not found standing in circumstances like these before. To the contrary, we have repeatedly held that mere offense, disagreement, or distaste does not qualify as a concrete and particularized injury,” the unsigned order said.

It is a major victory for Trump, whose ballroom project has become a signature effort of his second term and a political lightning rod [See **Ballroom**, A5]



JOHN LOCHER Associated Press



PARTH DESAI

FLOODWATERS ripped through Bright Angel Canyon, top, in the Grand Canyon over the weekend, leaving behind a raggedy path of destruction.

A deadly deluge fueled by extreme weather

Experts point to El Niño in Grand Canyon flood

By Karen Garcia and Ruben Vives

Epic flooding in the Grand Canyon that left at least two dead and more than a dozen missing was fueled in part by extreme weather, including the Southwest’s long-term drought, unusually high ocean temperatures and air from El Niño, forecasters said.

Flash flooding is common in northern Arizona, but experts say the amount of rain in the Grand Canyon this weekend was unusually high. Floodwater ripped through the popular recreational area, and officials were still searching for people who remained unaccounted for.

Chad Merrill, senior meteorologist and a long-range forecaster with AccuWeather, said the El Niño climate pattern has caused unusually high sea-surface temperatures in the eastern equatorial Pacific, increasing the moisture in the atmosphere that strengthened the Southwest monsoon.

The unusually warm waters between Southern California and Hawaii that

have contributed to a higher dew point and brought on the muggy conditions in Los Angeles are also delivering additional boosts in moisture and energy to those monsoon storms, he said.

The Grand Canyon’s typography also exacerbated the storm.

“At 7,000 feet on the South Rim [of the national park], we basically have a tremendous amount of uplift that causes convective storms, also known as hot air storms, [which produce] a massive amount of rainfall,” said Randy Cerveny, a meteorologist with Arizona State University.

“We get these convective thunderstorms many times during the course of the summer, but not of this kind of intensity,” he added.

Merrill said a persistent drought, which has prompted water restrictions at the Grand Canyon, allowed the heavy rainfall to run off quickly rather than be absorbed by [See **Flooding**, A6]

L.A. road deaths rise amid decline in stops by police

As some call for added traffic enforcement, others worry more pullovers lead to abuse.

By Libor Jany
and Hailey Wang

Marvin Reid can’t say how many pedestrians he’s seen get hit while trying to brave the North Hollywood intersection of Magnolia Boulevard and Tujunga Avenue. He gave up keeping count long ago.

One afternoon last spring, he watched as a man was struck while walking toward a 7-Eleven on the corner. Fortunately, the man popped to his feet “like nothing ever happened” and hustled into the store, Reid said. A week or two prior, he said, an out-of-control motorist nearly plowed into the statue of Amelia Earhart that sits next to a library bearing the famous aviator’s name.

“This is really a bad spot,” said Reid, who has helped run a Jamaican food pop-up at the busy street corner for five years. “It doesn’t matter if it’s an old lady crossing the street with a walker.”

The number of Angelenos who die in traffic

crashes now regularly outpaces those killed by homicide. From 2016 to 2023, the annual traffic death toll rose nearly 29% overall, and pedestrian deaths jumped roughly 54%. Fatal crashes fell slightly last year, but deaths still exceeded 300 in each of the last three years.

The city is rolling out 125 speed cameras in school zones, known street-racing corridors and places where speeding has contributed to a high rate of collisions — including Reid’s intersection.

But for him, the cameras aren’t a replacement for police traffic enforcement, which he said seems virtually nonexistent.

Even though LAPD squad cars are posted outside the library “every day,” he says, officers rarely do anything about the drivers who come careening off the exit ramps from the nearby 170 Freeway.

Similar complaints are being echoed around the city. Historically, Los Angeles — like other places across the U.S. — has relied on police stops for road safety. But in recent years, public pressure has compelled city leaders to think more critically about whether enforcement can continue without the [See **Traffic**, A6]

Labor support split in L.A. mayor race

Bass has backing of most unions, but hotel workers buck trend in favoring Raman.

By Noah Goldberg

Organized labor is heavily favoring incumbent Karen Bass, but Los Angeles mayoral challenger Nithya Raman scored a key endorsement Tuesday from Unite Here Local 11, the powerful union representing hospitality workers in hotels and airports.

Unite Here has emerged as a major player at City Hall, successfully pushing the Los Angeles City Council last year to pass a \$30 hourly minimum wage for hotel and airport workers ahead of the 2028 Olympics, although the council later delayed implementation.

In endorsing Raman, union President Kurt Petersen said the group believed in the City Council member’s commitment to fighting L.A.’s housing crisis, supporting the minimum wage hike and willingness to op-

pose short-term rental giant Airbnb — a key rival of Unite Here. Bass has supported delaying the minimum wage hike and expanding the short-term rental market, saying more beds will be needed for the 2028 Summer Olympics.

“Nithya has stood with us and our members through many fights,” Petersen said, noting that Raman was arrested as she protested with Unite Here workers in 2023 during their contract negotiations. “We believe [she] is the right person to help us solve the city’s problems.”

Petersen said Unite Here had the largest ground operation of any union in the state during primaries in June and knocked on more than 300,000 doors.

“Our endorsement means a lot more than a press release,” he said.

Raman still trails Bass significantly when it comes to the city’s major unions. Bass has more than 30 endorsements from unions across the region while Raman now has five, according to the candidates’ websites. [See **Mayor**, A7]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

A BICYCLIST rides past the boarded-up main entrance of the Hawthorne Plaza mall in Hawthorne.

Memories will be all that’s left of mall

Long-awaited work to tear down abandoned Hawthorne Plaza is bittersweet for locals.

By Karen Garcia

Even in a region known for its dead shopping malls, Hawthorne Plaza holds a unique distinction.

It has been closed longer than it was ever open, and the sprawling property in the center of the South Bay suburb has been the subject of debate and fascination for decades.

It opened along Haw-

thorne Boulevard in 1977, at the height of the mall-boom years, as every city wanted its air-conditioned main street anchored by department stores and plenty of parking.

But Hawthorne Plaza faltered earlier than most, shutting down in 1999 and remaining eerily preserved. The mall still has huge signs for the Broadway and Montgomery Ward, two once-famous department stores that went out of business decades ago.

The mall’s abandoned status has made it a setting for movies as well as urban adventurers, who have bro- [See **Mall**, A10]

2 bills boost solar options for renters

California lawmakers approve measures to expand access beyond rooftop systems.

By Blanca Begert
and Ian James

The California Legislature just passed two bills that advocates say will greatly improve access to small-scale solar for renters, people in condos and others who don’t have access to their roofs or can’t afford a full rooftop array.

On Sunday night, lawmakers approved Assembly Bill 1813, a third-time effort to force the California Public Utilities Commission to develop a more robust community solar program, in which residents sign up to participate in a small solar array near where they live and pay monthly at a discount on their electrical bills.

“California’s clean energy transition should benefit everyone, not just those who can afford rooftop solar,” said Assembly member Chris Ward (D-San Diego), the bill’s author.

Last week, with Senate Bill 868, California’s Legislature also became the latest to legalize plug-in solar. Also

known as “balcony solar,” these systems allow anyone — renter or owner — to set small panels on their patios or fences and plug them directly into wall outlets to lower bills without having to navigate utility permissions. “It’s an idea whose time has come,” said bill author Sen. Scott Wiener (D-San Francisco), who noted the devices can bring down bills by hundreds of dollars a year. “It’ll be very beneficial for people who are looking to lower their cost of living.”

The votes come after some difficult years for rooftop solar in California thanks to strong pushback from utility companies. The state had been a leader nationally on solar energy in the 2000s. But installation rates plummeted in 2022 after Gov. Gavin Newsom’s Public Utilities Commission sharply cut back incentives for customers.

Utilities that lobbied for the change argued that compensating rooftop solar at a higher rate meant that people without solar panels were disproportionately paying the costs of maintaining the overhead lines that everyone uses.

This year, utilities made similar arguments against both the community solar [See **Solar**, A7]



JAE C. HONG Associated Press

TRUMP TARGETS TRUCKERS

Officials announce the closure of 110 trucking schools, citing English proficiency failures and calling California a problem. **NATION**, A5

Warehouse odor finds a new home

Simi Valley residents complain as rotten food removed from L.A. fire site is dumped in local landfill. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Weather

Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 83/63. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

UCLA fires its athletic director

Jarmond is replaced by ex-Lakers executive Harris as chancellor cites debt. **SPORTS**, B10

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